African American Children's Mental Health Issues: Are They Being Properly Addressed?

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Statement of the Problem

- Socioeconomically disadvantaged African American communities are disproportionately impacted by stressful life circumstances, including community violence exposure, discrimination, lack of stability within the home, and other problems associated with poverty. (Attar et al, 1994; McLoyd, 1998; Simons et al. 2002; Evans et al. 2005; Gutman et al. 2005)
- Greater exposure to stressors may weaken children's ability to regulate emotions and effectively manage behaviors. (Evans et al. 2005; Gutman et al. 2005)
- How parents, teachers, and health professionals respond to children's externalizing and internalizing symptoms is critical to children's long-term well-being.

Methodology

The research utilizes both existing peer-reviewed literature and focus group data. The study examined the extent to which each type of data supports my conceptual model.

1. Peer-Reviewed Literature

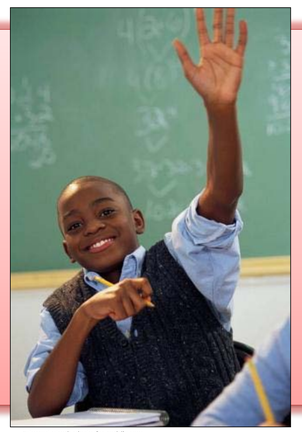
- Research articles were identified using PsychInfo and JSTOR electronic databases.
- Search terms included a combination of the following: African American, child, children, mental health, bias, discrimination, medication, behavioral problems, behavior, referral, disproportionate, special education, and teacher.

2. Focus Group Data

- Funding for the focus groups was provided by the University of Minnesota Program in Health Disparities Research.
- Two focus groups were conducted among parents whose children were aged 8-12 years (16 parents total).
- Parents were asked what they perceived to be the most important issues affecting the well-being and future success of young people, including how children's behavioral problems are addressed.
- I coded content that was relevant to my conceptual model into the themes to the far right.

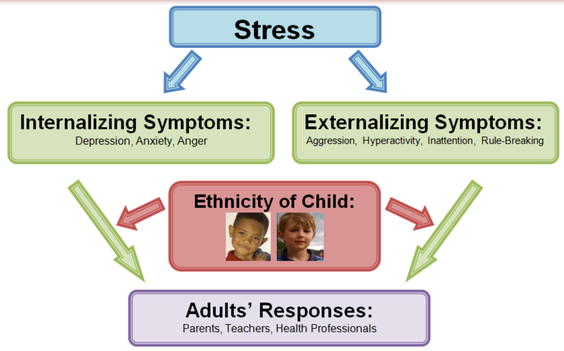


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Working Conceptual Model



Key Findings From Literature Review

Q1: How Do Adults Rate the Seriousness of Children's Problems?

- Lambert et al. (2001) used vignettes of African American children to test whether adults differed in their rating of the seriousness of behavioral and emotional problems.
- Sample: 42 parents, 53 teachers, 115 clinicians
- In comparison to clinicians, parents and teachers viewed externalizing problems as more serious.
- More clinicians than teachers or parents stated that children with internalizing symptoms had the greatest need for professional intervention.
- Marked disagreements between adults might lead to a lack of cooperation.

Q2: Do Teachers Differ in How They Refer African American and Caucasian Students for Problems?

- Andrews et al. (1997) examined the variables influencing teachers' decisions to refer children suspected of having developmental or behavioral problems.
- Sample: 213 children in a large, urban school district in Ohio
- In comparison to Caucasian children, African American children were referred at a disproportionate rate for developmental handicap services and were more likely to be classified as having mild mental retardation than a specific learning disability.

Q3: How Do Parents of Different Ethnic Backgrounds React to Health Professionals' Advice?

- Brown et al. (2007) investigated the association between race/ethnicity and parents' attitudes towards receiving advice about child mental health from a primary care provider (PCP).
- Sample: 773 parents who visited 54 PCPs in 13 diverse clinics
- African American parents reported *less* willingness to allow their children to receive medications than white and Hispanic parents, but did not differ in willingness for children to visit a therapist or belief that PCPs should treat children's mental health problems.

Key Findings From Focus Group Analysis

- Parents believed that African American children's mental health issues were not being properly addressed.
- Statements by parents suggest that inappropriate and/or inadequate responses to children's behavior are made by teachers, health professionals, and perhaps at times, the parents themselves. (See "Themes")

Theme: Ethnicity-Based Discrimination

Parents uniformly expressed concern that African American children are being discriminated against. Parents highlighted potential misdiagnosis, overmedication, and erroneous placement of African American children in special education:

"They don't need medication. They put some of the brightest kids in special ed. because of behavior. What they are teaching them has nothing to do with their behavior. They are teaching them like they are ignorant… they are in the 6th grade and they giving them 2nd grade work. They ain't dumb, they just got behavior problems."

Theme: Teachers' Monitoring of Children's Behavior

Parents had different views of whether teachers' monitoring of children's behavior was negative or positive:

"See, a lot of teachers just automatically just jump to it and say, 'Oh, well you got a problem so you need to get out of here. We need to call his parents right away instead of trying to see what is going on with that child, you just automatically label him, this is a bad child or something is wrong with that child."

"…when a teacher calls the home and told me that my daughter was not having a good day, she said that my daughter was easily tearful and my daughter is not usually like that. She is usually upbeat and having a good day and having fun at school… I think that it was nice for her [teacher] to call me to say something was wrong because she was acting out of the norm."

Theme: Lack of Awareness of Mental Health Issues

Many parents expressed doubt that their child could become depressed. Some parents provided useful examples to show that children could become depressed:

Saying in disbelief: ***"How does a kid that little get depressed?"***

"…why would a kid be depressed? That is a deep word to put on a kid."

"My children lost their father in [specific year] and then from [specific year] until now, I was in prison so I can say my kids was depressed for lack of me not being there and their father not being there. I think kids, to a certain extent, will get depressed and, you may not know it, but that is a sad feeling to lose your everything."

Conclusion & Recommendations

- Focus group data was consistent with findings from previous literature.
- Professional organizations and employers should provide cultural sensitivity training to health professionals and teachers. This will likely impact parents' receptiveness to and compliance with recommended treatment plans.
- Health professionals and teachers should assess and discuss African American parents' understanding of child mental health problems, their feelings about their child's diagnosis, and the implications of untreated mental health issues for their child.
- Health professionals need to *engage* parents and the African American community to promote awareness and involvement in the treatment process (e.g., community health fairs; school-based information sessions about mental health).